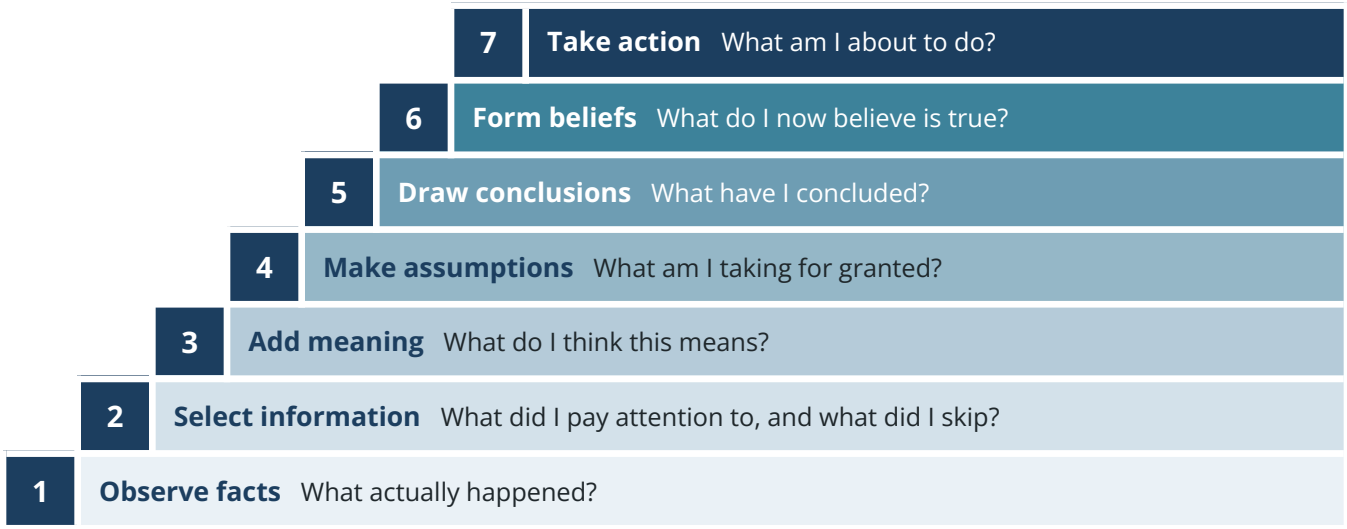
02 | LADDER OF INFERENCE | RESOURCE

Ladder of Inference: How Assumptions Form

The seven steps between seeing something and acting on it

The Ladder of Inference maps how we get from an observation to an action. Most of the time we climb it without noticing. Knowing the steps makes it easier to catch the moment a guess starts to feel like a fact.



START HERE • Read from 1 at the bottom to 7 at the top.

The feedback loop

What we believe shapes what we notice. If you're sure a coworker never replies, every late answer stands out and the quick ones fade from memory. Look for the evidence that doesn't fit.

> **A tool for yourself**
> Use the ladder to check your own thinking, not to label someone else. Stick to what you saw or heard. Ask a neutral question and listen to the answer. Even a reasonable conclusion may need checking.

Based on: Decision & Escalation training, Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."

Learn more: TED-Ed lesson | USC explanation of the seven steps

02 | LADDER OF INFERENCE | RESOURCE (CONTINUED)

Ladder of Inference: Example and Practice

Example only. This is not a real County case.

Steps	What happens
1–2. Facts and focus	Your supervisor writes back, "Please send your recommendation." You focus on the request, but you don't know what your supervisor still needs.
3–4. Meaning and assumptions	You take the reply as a brush-off and decide the outcome is already settled. Your supervisor never said either thing.
5–7. Conclusion, belief, and action	You figure your input won't count and the process is pointless. You stall, or you send a frustrated reply.

What to do instead

> **Ask before you assume**
> "I can put together a recommendation. What decision is it for, what should I include, and when do you need it?"

Then sort out who does what. You might own the research while someone else owns the approval. Send the facts you've checked, the open question, and the next step you suggest.

Practice with something current

Use this space	Your notes
What happened	
What I assumed, or another possibility	
Who I'll ask, and what	
My next step	

When your thinking changes

> *"I thought _____. Then I checked _____ and found out _____. Now I'm going to _____."*

Based on: Decision & Escalation training, Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."